Nair spoke, ‘The first time I saw you, this morning, I got the feeling that you will speak the truth. That’s why I kept this session with you the last. Now, Mr Nambi Narayanan, tell us all about you and the charges you face.’

He was firm and clear in his words, but very different from the threatening ways of the Kerala Police and the IB. I felt reassured.

I sat still for a minute or two, gathering my thoughts. I decided to be as articulate and lucid as possible. I divided my story, mentally, into three parts. First, my family background, my financial situation and my commitments to my sisters and some other relatives; second my professional background and achievements; and the third about whatever little I tried to understand about what they called the ISRO spy case.

I tried hard not to show my emotions as I spoke about my father, mother, my commitment to my sisters, their marriage, my struggle through the engineering college and the lost opportunity to study abroad because of my mother’s ill-health.

Sharma and Nair listened intently, in silence.

The second part of my story was more of a presentation of pride; how I joined ISRO, my meeting and association with Vikram Sarabhai and A P J Abdul Kalam; how I led a team of more than fifteen Indian scientists to collaborate with the French and develop the Viking/Vikas engine which helped launch India’s first two PSLV rockets only months earlier. I also told them something I had not told anyone else: my plan to quit ISRO sooner than later, purely to make more money so that I can take care of some dependents in my extended family.

The two officers sat poker-faced.

The third part, I told them, about the so called espionage case, was just a figment of imagination. All that I knew about the case was through the questions the IB men had thrown at me. I told Sharma and Nair that this case is a complete frame-up since rocket secrets cannot be transferred through paper, it needed intense hands-on collaboration and training for years—the way we developed the Vikas engine. I raised the suspicion that I could have been falsely implicated in the case, but I did not know the reason beyond the fact that several people in ISRO were not my fans since I